

Colds, Flu, & Fevers

The common cold, with which most of us are only too familiar, is a viral infection normally affecting the nose and throat. Flu is considerably more debilitating and may include fever, headache, muscular pain, nausea, and vomiting. Both have a habit of striking when we are stressed or run down. Herbal home treatment is especially suitable for these familiar “self-limiting” ailments since it enables us to make life more comfortable, control fever, and improve the body’s recovery rate.

Garlic, ginger, and lemon combine to create the classic flu remedy that can also be used to relieve colds, sore throats, and tonsillitis.

Ginger, cinnamon, cloves, and cayenne have heating properties and stimulate sweating. This helps to lower the body’s temperature during fever.

Elderberry and yarrow are antiviral, stimulate sweating, and astringe the mucous membranes of the nose and throat, reducing the production of mucus.

Boneset and cayenne are particularly helpful for respiratory infections.

Wormwood and gentian are bitter herbs that cool the body and combat high fever.

Diet

For all these problems, eat lightly. Fruit and vegetables are best, the latter perhaps in a soup. Avoid greasy, fatty, sugar-rich food and dairy products.

Self-help

Reduce fever and temperature by washing with cool or cold water and drinking plenty of liquid, especially when sweating.

❗ **General cautions** Remember that in the very young and very old, even a common cold can develop into pneumonia. Always seek professional advice if symptoms persist or suddenly get worse.

General Remedies

Herbs Garlic (*Allium sativum*, p. 59), ginger (*Zingiber officinale*, p. 155), lemon (*Citrus limon*, p. 82)

Remedy Crush a medium-sized garlic clove, grate a similarly sized piece of fresh ginger, and squeeze the juice from 1 lemon. Mix together with 1 tsp of honey. Add $\frac{3}{4}$ cup (150 ml) of warm water and stir. Drink up to 1½ cups (450 ml) a day while symptoms last.

Herbs Thyme (*Thymus vulgaris*, p. 143), boneset (*Eupatorium perfoliatum*, p. 208)

Remedy Make an infusion using $\frac{1}{2}$ tsp of each herb with $\frac{3}{4}$ cup (150 ml) of water and then drink 1½–2½ cups (450–600 ml) a day.

Note This remedy is very effective if thick green mucus and nasal congestion occur.

Colds

Herbs Lemon (*Citrus limon*, p. 82), cinnamon (*Cinnamomum* spp., p. 81)

Remedy Drink the freshly squeezed juice of 1 lemon, neat or diluted in warm water.

Option Add 1 tsp of honey to the juice and $\frac{1}{2}$ tsp of cinnamon powder.

Herb Ginger (*Zingiber officinale*, p. 155)

Remedy Infuse 2–3 slices (1 g) of fresh ginger with $\frac{3}{4}$ cup (150 ml) of water for 5 minutes. Take up to 3 cups (750 ml) a day.

Herbs Elderberry (*Sambucus nigra*, p. 132), lemon (*Citrus limon*, p. 82)

Remedy Take 1 tsp (5 ml) of elderberry tincture or extract in warm water up to 3 times a day. Add in freshly squeezed juice from half a lemon.

High Fever

Herbs Yarrow (*Achillea millefolium*, p. 56), boneset (*Eupatorium perfoliatum*, p. 208), cayenne (*Capsicum frutescens*, p. 74)

Remedy Make an infusion using 1 tsp each of yarrow and boneset, with a pinch of cayenne, to $\frac{3}{4}$ cup (150 ml) of water. Brew for 5 minutes and drink hot. Take up to 2½ cups (600 ml) a day.

Options Add 1 or 2 of the following herbs: 2–3 cloves (*Eugenia caryophyllata*, p. 97), $\frac{1}{2}$ tsp of powdered or grated fresh ginger (*Zingiber officinale*, p. 155), $\frac{1}{2}$ tsp of chopped or powdered cinnamon bark (*Cinnamomum* spp., p. 81), 1–2 crushed cardamom seeds (*Elettaria cardamomum*, p. 93), 2–3 crushed peppercorns (*Piper nigrum*, p. 250).

Caution Do not take yarrow during pregnancy.

Herbs Wormwood (*Artemisia absinthium*, p. 66), gentian (*Gentiana lutea*, p. 99)

Remedy Take 10 drops of either tincture with water 3 times a day in addition to the above remedy.

Caution Do not take wormwood during pregnancy.

Mild Fever

Herbs Yarrow (*Achillea millefolium*, p. 56), elderberry (*Sambucus nigra*, p. 132)

Remedy Make an infusion with $\frac{1}{2}$ tsp of each herb in $\frac{1}{2}$ cup (100 ml) water. Brew for 10 minutes and drink up to 2½ cups (600 ml) a day.

Caution Do not take yarrow during pregnancy.

Herb Onion (*Allium cepa*, p. 164)

Remedy Bake a large onion at 400°F (200°C) for 40 minutes. Remove, and mix the juice with an equal amount of honey. Take 1–2 tsp an hour up to 8 times a day.

Flu with Muscle Aches & Pains

Herbs Thyme (*Thymus vulgaris*, p. 143), lemon balm (*Melissa officinalis*, p. 113), elderflower (*Sambucus nigra*, p. 132)

Remedy Make an infusion using 5 g of each herb to 3 cups (750 ml) of water. Brew for 10 minutes and drink up to 3 cups (750 ml) a day.

Herb Echinacea (*Echinacea* spp., p. 92)

Remedy Take tablets or capsules, or up to $\frac{1}{2}$ tsp of tincture with water twice a day. Alternatively, make a decoction with 5 g of root to 3 cups (750 ml) of water and then drink 1¼–2½ cups (300–600 ml) a day.

Sore Throats & Tonsillitis

The garlic, ginger, and lemon mixture listed under *General Remedies for Colds, Flu, & Fevers* (see above) can alleviate the symptoms of both sore throats and tonsillitis. The brave can slowly chew a clove of garlic; sage and echinacea are also strongly antiseptic. All these herbs will relieve symptoms and aid a speedy recovery.

❗ **General caution** Always seek professional advice and treatment for children under 5 suffering from tonsillitis.

Sore Throats

Herbs Tamarind (*Tamarindus indica*, p. 274), lemon (*Citrus limon*, p. 82)

Remedy Gargle with either a decoction of tamarind fruit or 1 tbsp (20 ml) of lemon juice, either neat or diluted in warm water.

Herbs Rosemary (*Rosmarinus officinalis*, p. 128), sage (*Salvia officinalis*, p. 131), myrrh (*Commiphora molmol*, p. 85), echinacea (*Echinacea* spp., p. 92)

Remedy 1 Dilute 1 tsp of equal parts of all tinctures in 5 tsp of warm water and gargle. Swallow the mixture (except if pregnant).

Remedy 2 Make a sage infusion, brew for

10 minutes, and allow to cool a little. Gargle, then swallow. Add 1 tsp (5 ml) of vinegar and 1 tsp of honey to strengthen its action.

Caution Do not swallow sage during pregnancy.

Tonsillitis

Herbs Echinacea (*Echinacea* spp., p. 92), all herbs listed under *Sore Throats*

Remedy Take echinacea (see *Flu with Muscle Aches & Pains* above), or use one of the gargles listed under *Sore Throats*.

❗ **Caution** Seek professional advice if there is no improvement after 2 days.